

Overcalls

Because of the Defensive element, the most important requirement for an Overcall is that you have a good suit, one that you'd like partner to lead. Keep in mind:

- a 5-card or longer suit with honor strength

- 9-16 points to overcall at the 1-level

- 11-16 points to overcall at the 2-level

Takeout Doubles

There are three kinds of Takeout Double:

- opening hand strength, no more than 2 of opponent's suit, at least 3 in all other suits
- strong Overcall type, at least 17 points and a good suit. Double, then bid the suit.
- strong Notrump type, 19+ points, stopper in their suit. Double, then bid notrump.

Responding to a Takeout Double

- 0-8 points, bid your best suit as cheaply as possible

- 9-11 points, jump in your best suit

- 12 or more points, cue-bid the opponent's suit

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 1♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣9

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣K

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 1♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣K

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9
 ♥ K 9 6 3
 ♦ 10 8 6 5
 ♣ J 4 3

♠ A Q J 6 4 2

♥ A 7

♦ J 7 2

♣ A 8



♠ 8 3

♥ Q J 10 4

♦ A 9 4

♣ K Q 10 5

♠ K 7 5

♥ 8 5 2

♦ K Q 3

♣ 9 7 6 2

There is only one reason that NORTH should not overcall with 1 ♠. He is too strong. The maximum strength of an overcall is 16 points. Above that you should double.

So NORTH doubles, and after SOUTH bids 2 ♣, NORTH bids 2 ♠. This shows an overcall type hand, but with 17 or more points.

SOUTH has fine trump support and 8 points so she bids a confident 4 ♠.

West	North	East	South
1 ♥	Dbl	Pass	2 ♣
Pass	2 ♠	Pass	4 ♠
All Pass			
4 ♠ by North			
Lead: ♥Q			

Board 2

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q J 2
 ♥ A K 4 3
 ♦ 7 4
 ♣ K Q 8 2

♠ A 7 6
 ♥ Q 8 5
 ♦ A 9 3 2
 ♣ 10 9 4



♠ K 9 8 3
 ♥ 7 6
 ♦ K Q 5
 ♣ A J 7 6

♠ 10 5 4
 ♥ J 10 9 2
 ♦ J 10 8 6
 ♣ 5 3

EAST has 13 points but has no bid over 1♦. WEST can make a Takeout Double, so he does.

EAST now cue-bids ♦ to show opening hand strength.

WEST shows his ♥ suit, EAST doesn't like it. EAST shows her ♠ suit, WEST doesn't like it. WEST shows his ♣ suit, EAST likes it fine, but decides 3NT will be easier than 5♣.

West	North	East	South
	1♦	Pass	Pass
Dbl	Pass	2♦	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♣	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♦ J			

Board 3

South Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A J 10 7 4

♥ A 7 3

♦ A 8 6

♣ 9 5

♠ Q 5 3

♥ 9 8 4

♦ 10 3 2

♣ A J 7 4



♠ 9 6

♥ Q 6 5

♦ J 7 5 4

♣ K 10 6 2

♠ K 8 2

♥ K J 10 2

♦ K Q 9

♣ Q 8 3

WEST would have had a great opening 1♠ bid. But when SOUTH opened 1♠ in front of him he was hornswaggled. He couldn't bid any other suit, he couldn't bid 1NT and he sure couldn't bid ♠s. So he must pass.

And so does everybody else pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♠

All Pass

1♠ by South

Lead: ♣9

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

♠ K Q J 9 7 5 3
♥ 7 4
♦ Q 3
♣ 6 2

♠ 10 4

♥ K 9 6 3

♦ A 4 2

♣ A K J 9

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 8 2

♥ J 5 2

♦ K 9 8 6

♣ 7 5 3

♠ 6

♥ A Q 10 8

♦ J 10 7 5

♣ Q 10 8 4

*West**North**East**South*

3♠

All Pass

3♠ by West

Lead: ♣K

1♣

If South had passed, WEST would have opened with a preemptive 3♠.

She should make the same bid with the same hand AFTER the opponents open. And she makes it for the same reason, to describe her hand and to take away bidding space from the opponents.

EAST treats it just like a Preemptive 3-bid, even though it is now called a Weak Jump Overcall. In this case, EAST passes.

Board 5

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 6 3
♥ A K 7
♦ 9 4 2
♣ A 10 7 5

♠ A J 10 8 5

♥ 6 3

♦ A J 10 8 5

♣ 3



♠ Q 4
♥ 10 9 8 2
♦ K Q 7
♣ K Q J 2

♠ K 7 2

♥ Q J 5 4

♦ 6 3

♣ 9 8 6 4

NORTH has 12 points, but with two 5-card suits worthy of an overcall. There isn't really a right and wrong here, but it usually works out best to overcall in the higher-ranking suit. That leaves open the possibility of bidding the second suit later.

In this Deal, after NORTH overcalls 1♠, that later possibility never happens because everybody should pass.

West

1♣

North

1♠

*East**South*

All Pass

1♠ by North

Lead: ♣K